

FREE PRINTABLE

The Manager's Field Kit

Useful things for the weeks when the number, the team, or both are giving you trouble.

I've taken over teams that were doing great, teams that were struggling, and a few that were already on fire when I got there. Some I fixed. A couple I made worse before I made them better.

No management methodology here, and no certification at the end. Just the stuff that kept being useful: figuring out whether the problem is the rep or the territory, getting an honest forecast, knowing if there's really enough pipeline, helping a rep who's struggling, defending your people at review time, and keeping your boss from getting surprised.

Don't read it front to back. **Find the problem you have this week and start there.** Each chapter ends with the worksheet that goes with it.

Having a bad week? Start here.

Where the number came from	Chapter 1	Pipeline problem	Chapter 7
Quota or comp plan problem	Chapter 2	Boss problem	Chapter 8
Handing down a tough number	Chapter 3	Review season	Chapter 10
Rep problem	Chapter 4 or 9	High performers	Chapter 13
Forecast problem	Chapter 6		

1. How your team's number got built

Nobody built your team's number by looking at your team. At a cloud provider it starts with prior year revenue plus a growth rate, usually set above the geo VP, then gets spread down by region, segment and territory. In SaaS it's last year's ARR or bookings plus whatever the company promised its board. Either way, nobody in your chain actually picked the number. They divided it up.

Every layer adds cushion. Most sales plans are over-assigned, and a common planning rule of thumb is 20 to 30%. That's why your reps' quotas can add up to more than your own number, and why a team can miss while the region makes it.

Then find out what your boss is actually paid on, because it often isn't your number. Your VP might be goaled on growth rate, new business, new logos, consumption, margin, or a strategic program you've never heard of. Ask directly: "What are you measured on this year?"

It changes what you fight for. If your boss is paid on growth rate and your baseline includes a one-time spike, fixing that baseline helps both of you, and now you have an ally. If your boss is paid on new logos, a plan built entirely on expansion won't get much help from above.

Before you argue with anything, know your own baseline: prior year revenue by territory, what in it won't repeat, accounts that moved in or out, vacant territories, and who's still ramping. A vacant territory still has quota. Somebody's carrying it.

Worksheet: What your number is made of

What my boss is paid on _____ Date _____

TERRITORY	PRIOR YEAR REVENUE	ONE - TIME IN IT	RUN RATE NOW	QUOTA	RAMPED?

2. Fighting the plan without losing

Most managers who fight the plan do it too late, get emotional, and argue about everything at once. The ones I've seen actually move a number went about it differently.

Start early. The best time to shape your team's quota was last year, during planning, while the spreadsheet was still open and somebody upstairs was asking for input. The next best time is now. Once the numbers lock, the growth rate won't move, but some of the inputs still can.

Put it on one page: prior year revenue minus one-time revenue, your current run rate, committed contracts landing this year, qualified pipeline at your real win rate, and capacity (ramped reps, open territories, how long ramp really takes). Then the gap. Keep the adjectives out of it.

Ask for things that can actually move: the baseline, territory assignments, when new headcount lands, ramp relief for new reps, and crediting for partner and marketplace deals. Asking to change a growth rate your VP was handed just tells your VP you don't know how it works.

Make one ask, in writing, once. If the answer doesn't make sense, escalate once. After that, commit to the number in front of your team and mean it. If you keep fighting a number after you've handed it down, you'll lose the team.

Know when to stop. If there's a real answer to the gap, if the growth rate came from above your VP, or if your one page can't find the missing assumption, you're done arguing. Now it's a plan, and it's chapter 3.

Worksheet: The one-page case

Date _____ Online: quotabird.com/quota-case

THE EVIDENCE	\$ OR COUNT
Prior year revenue, minus one-time revenue	
Current run rate ($\text{MRR} \times 12$)	
Committed contracts landing this year	
Qualified pipeline $\times$ win rate	
Capacity: ramped reps, vacancies, months of ramp	
The number	
The gap	

The one ask, who it went to, and when

3. Handing down a tough number, and still crushing it

At some point you'll hand your team a number you don't love. How you hand it down decides whether they spend the year arguing about it or working on it.

Own it. "Corporate made me do it" turns you into a messenger, and people don't follow messengers. You don't have to say the number is fair. Say it's the number and that you checked it.

Show them the math: prior year revenue, the growth rate, where the team's number came from, and what you pushed back on and whether you got it. Reps take a hard number a lot better when they can see it didn't come out of nowhere.

Give every rep a path: their gap, the new pipeline it takes at their win rate, and how much of that should come from existing accounts versus net-new ones. If a rep can't see how to get there, don't be surprised when they start updating their LinkedIn.

Start early. On a run-rate number, a workload that lands in Q1 is worth about three times the same workload in Q4, so spend January building pipeline instead of reviewing the forecast.

After that, stop reopening it. Talk about the gap every week, and stop debating whether the number is fair. Give people credit for pipeline they build early, as well as for deals they close.

If you're the rep in this chapter, the Seller's Field Kit has the same conversation from the other side.

Worksheet: Every rep's path

Quarter _____

REP	QUOTA	GAP	NEW PIPELINE NEEDED	FROM EXISTING	FROM NET - NEW

4. You inherited a team. Don't grade everybody yet.

My first mistake as a new manager was deciding pretty quickly who was good and who wasn't. I got a lot of that wrong, mostly because I hadn't looked at their territories yet.

Before I decide a rep has a performance problem, I want to know whether the territory is any good, what's installed already, whether the quota is remotely reasonable, what the last rep did there, what the comp plan rewards, and whether there are enough customers who can buy what we sell.

If three good people failed in the same territory, I start with the territory.

Then I look at the rep, and I mean the rep, before the CRM. Do customers want to spend time with them? Have they created anything that wouldn't exist without them? Can they sell when they're in the room? Are they still trying?

The most useful thing I did with a new team was sit with each rep and go through five real deals. Every once in a while, the rep who drives you nuts internally is the one customers keep calling back.

My first month. Week 1: meet everybody, ask what they'd change. Week 2: size the territories. Week 3: sit in deals and customer calls. Week 4: tell your boss what you found.

Worksheet: Rep diagnostic

Rep _____ Date _____ Online: quotabird.com/rep

IN THIS ORDER	YES / SORT OF / NO	NOTES
Territory: could a good rep make this number here?		
Customers: do they want time with this rep?		
Pipeline: is there pipeline only this rep created?		
Craft: can they sell in the room?		
Will: are they still trying to win?		

Territory is no: fix the situation. Craft is no: coach. Will is no: manage. If both are no in a fair territory, read chapter 9.

5. Keep the 1:1 and the forecast call separate

A 1:1 and a forecast call aren't the same meeting. The 1:1 is about the person and the forecast call is about the number, and whenever I mixed them, both got worse.

My 1:1 was usually thirty minutes, and the rep went first. What are they working on? What's getting in their way? What am I doing that's getting in their way? Then we look at one real deal properly.

I finish with one thing I saw them do well, one thing I'd try differently, and anything I said I'd do. I write down what I committed to and then actually do it, which built more trust than anything else I tried.

Once a month I'd ask, "If you were running this team, what would you change?" You'll hear things nobody says in the staff meeting.

If people only bring you good news, you'll hear the bad news from your boss first. I want to hear "this deal is slipping" on Monday. If reps keep deals green until Friday, they're afraid of the meeting, and that's usually on the manager.

Worksheet: One-on-one

Rep _____ Date _____

Their list: what's in their way, including me

One deal: customer, money, power, path, now

One thing they did well, one thing to try

What I said I'd do, and by when

6. What commit means

To me, commit means the customer could explain how the money gets from them to us, and roughly when. Anything less is a guess. Most shaky deals break in one of five places:

WHERE IT BREAKS	WHAT I'M REALLY ASKING
Customer	Do they actually want to solve this?
Money	Is there real money attached to it?
Power	Are we connected to somebody who can make it happen?
Path	Do we know how they actually buy?
Now	Why does anything happen this period?

The best forecast question I know is still **"Who told you that?"** Not "what do you think," not "how confident are you." Who told you, and when? A named customer and a date beats enthusiasm every time. I've forecast plenty of enthusiasm. It has a terrible close rate.

When a rep and I disagree, I ask which of the five they'd defend to my boss, and we forecast that. Nobody has to lose face.

One question I ask a lot: what changed? If nothing changed at the customer, the deal didn't move, whatever the CRM says.

Worksheet: Deal inspection

Deal _____ Rep _____ Online: quotabird.com/deal

QUESTION	YES / SORT OF / NO	WHO SAID SO, AND WHEN
Customer: have they said they want to solve this?		
Money: does it have a name and a fiscal year?		
Power: have we met who can make it happen?		
Path: do we know the vehicle and the approvals?		
Now: what makes it happen this period?		

I only call it commit with five answers I'd defend to my boss.

7. Pipeline has two jobs

Managers usually ask, "Do we have enough pipeline?" I'd ask one more: will it survive your champion leaving? Different question.

Enough. The 3X rule everybody repeats assumes roughly a 33% win rate. The math is simple: coverage needed is one divided by your win rate. Use your own team's qualified win rate.

WIN RATE	COVERAGE NEEDED
15%	6.7X
20%	5.0X
25%	4.0X
33%	3.0X
40%	2.5X

Sturdy. A team can have 4X coverage and still be in trouble. So I also ask what happens if our biggest deal slips, whether the commit deals are moving, whether each one has a next step the customer owns, how much is back-loaded into the last month, and whether we're creating new pipeline or just aging the old stuff.

Run the forecast once without your biggest deal. That's the plan I'd manage.

Worksheet: Team pipeline

Quarter _____ Date _____ Online: quotabird.com/pipeline

REP	NUMBER	QUALIFIED PIPELINE	WIN RATE	COVERAGE NEEDED (1 ÷ WIN RATE)	COVERAGE NOW	BIGGEST DEAL

If one deal is carrying a big chunk of the number, know exactly what happens if it moves.

8. Your boss mostly wants fewer surprises

Early on I kept sending my boss more information, when mostly they just didn't want to be surprised.

My update fits on one page: the number (commit, best case, gap), what changed and why, what worries me, what I'm doing about it, and one ask with a date. Or "nothing this week." And I lead with the bad news. "Heads up before this shows up in the CRM" beats letting your boss discover it.

I learned another one the expensive way. When somebody above me handed me a number I couldn't see, I used to say, "We'll find a way." Sometimes we did. Sometimes I spent the rest of the year explaining that sentence. Now I'd say, "Here's what I can commit to with what we have. Here's what would have to be true to get to your number." Then I show the math. Longer version:

quotabird.com/notes/prove-the-quota-is-crazy

Worksheet: The five-minute boss update

Week of _____

Commit	
Best case	
Gap	

What changed, and why

Biggest risk

What I'm doing about it

What I need from you, and by when

9. Before you write up a rep

Four very different problems can produce the same ugly dashboard.

PROBLEM	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHAT I DO
Bad situation	Good rep. Bad territory, quota, accounts or plan.	Fix the situation.
Skill	They're working, customers engage, deals just aren't converting.	Coach. Sit in the room.
Effort	They know how to sell. They're just not doing enough of it.	Set expectations clearly, in writing, with dates.
Wrong fit	Fair territory, enough support, and neither the skill nor the effort is there.	Now it's a performance conversation.

Before I call it a performance problem, I make sure the rep knows what good looks like next Tuesday, not someday. I spent months once coaching somebody whose territory couldn't have produced the number. I'd like those months back. So would the rep.

The rep diagnostic is in chapter 4. Online: quotabird.com/rep

10. Review season: bring receipts

Nobody in the calibration room saw your rep's whole year. They saw whatever case you brought in. That took me too long to figure out.

I keep a running note during the year: date, what happened, result. Nothing elaborate. Then I'm not digging through six months of email and Slack in November.

For each rep I want three meaningful results (with numbers where numbers make sense), what happened because this person was there, why the work was at their level, specific examples behind any behavior I'm going to claim, and the harder thing I'd trust them with next.

I say the weakest part of my case first, since they'll find it anyway.

I also check myself. Am I overweighting the last sixty days? Would I see this person differently if I didn't personally like working with them? Take away their biggest win: does my view hold? Take away their worst month: same question.

Worksheet: Talent review prep

Rep _____ Level _____ Online: quotabird.com/talent-review

Three results, with numbers where they make sense

What happened because this person was there

Why the work was at their level

Examples behind each behavior I'll claim

The harder thing I'd trust them with next

The weakest part of this case, said first

11. Things I learned the expensive way

Managing the dashboard. The CRM got cleaner and the pipeline stayed flat.

- **Saving the deal myself.** Worked great once. Then the rep learned to wait for me.
- **Managing the average.** Two reps at 6X and two at 1X isn't a healthy team at 3.5X.
- **Forecasting confidence.** Some people sound sure about everything. I don't count that as evidence.

- **Waiting to deliver bad news.** I wanted the fix before I told my boss. They'd have preferred the news Monday and the fix Friday.
- **Giving everyone the same 1:1.** My best seller and my newest seller needed completely different things from those thirty minutes.
- **Discounting the wrong problem.** I approved a discount when the real issue was access to power. We solved a price problem the customer didn't have.
- **Talking too much on customer calls.** I thought I was helping the rep. Mostly I was teaching the customer to look at me instead of them.

Being the answer machine. Eventually people brought me every problem and stopped deciding anything.

12. A few lines worth stealing

WHEN	WHAT I SAY
A shaky deal	"Who told you that, and when?"
Moving something out of commit	"Which part would you defend to my boss?"
A rep is missing	"Forget the number for a minute. What's getting in your way?"
The target from above doesn't match reality	"Here's what I can commit to with what I have. Here's what has to change to get to that."
Bad news	"Heads up before this lands in the CRM."
A discount request	"What are we getting for it?"
A hard performance conversation	"Here's what good looks like thirty days from now."
You don't know	"I don't know. I'll find out by Thursday." Then find out by Thursday.

13. Managing high performers

The easiest way to lose a great seller is to manage them like everybody else. I've done it.

Mostly, I leave them alone. When customers call them back, they build their own pipeline and they tell me bad news before I find it, the system is working. My job is a fair territory, clearing what slows them down, helping when they ask, and keeping the rest of the company from improving them to death.

And don't punish them for being good. The reward for making the number shouldn't be a bigger number, three accounts nobody else could handle, and coaching the new hires on their own time.

Once a quarter I ask three things. What would make this job better? What do you want to be doing in two years? What am I asking of you that isn't worth your time? Then I act on at least one answer. Great sellers rarely leave over money alone. They leave when nobody noticed they were bored.

Sometimes you just need another set of eyes

A free twenty-minute call, no pitch. · mark@quotabird.com · quotabird.com/about